February). The plan was to charge a rate lower than BI.[12] The revenue the company hoped to generate by ferrying pilgrims across a six-mile stretch could not have been much and was little more than a sign of desperation. The plan never materialized.

Lionel Davidson, the Tirunelveli collector, on his visit to Colombo on 8 February, found both the Swadeshi steamers lying in the harbour. But, on his way back to Tuticorin two days later, the *Lawoe* was gone. Curious about its fate, on inquiry he found that it was docked, and that the scraping and painting contractors had demanded a deposit of Rs 1,500 amounting to two-thirds of the estimated costs. The plan now was to sail between Kakinada and Rangoon.[13] Once again, nothing came of these efforts.

In March, K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, who, in tandem with S.D. Krishna Aiyangar had heroically shouldered the responsibility of SSNCo in the face of the greatest adversities, shifted his legal practice to Madurai, it was said, on the advice of his brother. The police noticed that he was travelling frequently, with a railway season ticket, to Tirunelveli and Tuticorin from Madurai on Swadeshi company business. Probably, there was residual work in Tuticorin. But the sleuths confessed that ‘it is a difficult matter to find out much about his business, as he refuses to be drawn out in conversation’. If Venkatarama Aiyar was sullen, and consequently withdrawn, it is quite understandable. There was little left to be done at Tuticorin for indefatigable managers such as Venkatarama Aiyar.[14]

Despite little progress in the company’s affairs, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar sailed to Colombo from Tuticorin on 17 March, accompanied by two servants.[15] Soon, an advertisement signed by him appeared, calling on the public to buy shares and requesting ‘agents of a young age filled with patriotism’ to help the company’s cause.[16] Notwithstanding the withdrawal of K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar appears to have continued to hope for a miracle.

In March 1910, Mandayam S. Parthasarathy—who had managed SSNCo’s Calcutta branch office during that year—arrived in Tuticorin after meeting his brother, S. Srinivasachari in Pondicherry. The police reported